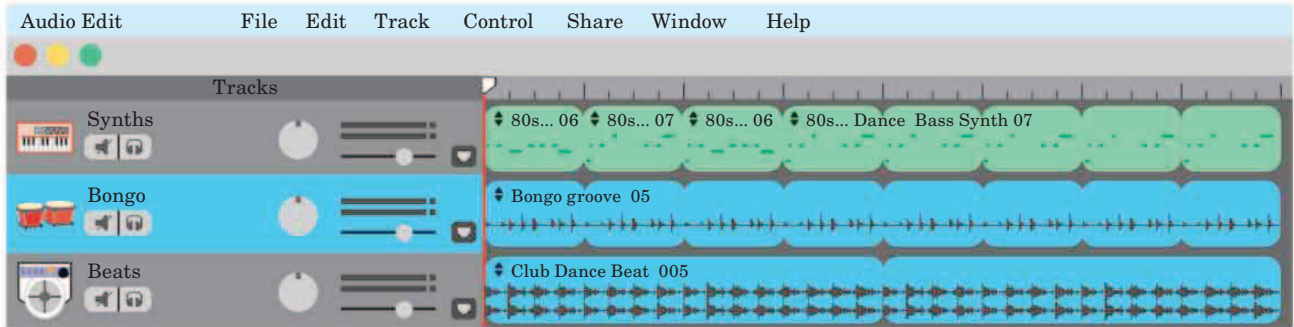


Loop

When an ostinato is used in electronic music it is called a loop. Short sections of music can be created and repeated easily in composing software programs, synthesizers, or sequencers. Often composers will sample (or digitally appropriate a portion of sound from) a small bit of music from an existing piece, to use as a loop in a new piece.

▽ A software loop

Here is an example of synthesizer, bongo drum, and DJ beat loops premade and layered on top of each other. The synth and bongo loops are one four-count measure.



Riff

The term “riff” is used in pop, rock, and jazz music. Riffs are usually repeated material used as a melody, accompanied by instruments that play the changing harmonies underneath. Also known as “the hook” or a “lick,” riffs can be extremely catchy and memorable, as in Eric Clapton and Cream’s 1967 hit “Sunshine of Your Love.” They do not repeat as many times in a row as an ostinato, unless they are accompanimental, as seen below.

▽ Bluesy riff

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Riffs may be repeated over and over if they serve as the background to a melodic improvisation, as shown in this example from the blues style.



REAL WORLD

Eric Clapton



British singer-songwriter and guitarist Eric Clapton’s most famous riffs are so revered by guitar enthusiasts that entire books and websites are devoted to dissecting and analyzing his blues, pop, rock, and folk performances. In addition to the tune discussed above, Clapton’s 1970 song “Layla,” recorded with his band Derek and the Dominoes, features some of the most iconic, recognizable guitar riffs of all time.

“I’d love to **knock** an **audience cold** with **one note**, but what do you do for the rest of the **evening**?”
Eric Clapton
